

Films of 1970



Rules: Oscar nominees in major categories were watched. BAFTA and Golden Globes nominees were usually watched as well. A 1970 US release was usually stuck to concerning eligibility. A few foreign language films were included, but only stand outs as well as available spaghetti westerns and giallo. Given that we are firmly within the start of New American Cinema, how many liberties the film took will factor in. Also during this time films started to be films on-location more, which will also be factored in.

Tier 9: The Worst B-Movies of the Year

85. **Angels Die Hard:** An absolute mess of a biker gang film. There isn't much of a plot at all. The camerawork is shoddy. The acting is rather terrible; the nerdy boy who loves the sheriff's daughter is the worst. There is a spaghetti rape scene which should tell you all you need to know about the film's quality. Like other biker gang films, had it took just a little bit of time to build characters and expand on its anti-cop and anti-establishment themes, it could move up a tier or two. But instead, it rehashing genre tropes without ever going anywhere. [Outlaw Biker Gang]
84. **Hercules in New York:** Known for being the film debut of Arnold Schwarzenegger, as he plays the titular Hercules. Yet, all of his dialogue is dubbed by someone else. The dubbing itself isn't very good and is cheap. The entire film is cheap. The other actors are bad, the script is bad. The fights are pathetic. Outside of seeing a young Arnold, there is nothing of value in this film. It also never even achieves so-bad-its-good status. [Arnold Schwarzenegger]
83. **Black Angels:** Also known as *Black Bikers from Hell*. The film is far too cheap to rank any higher. The fights are laughably bad. Much of the 85-minute runtime is spent on choppy shots of bikes riding around. There are a few characters but none of them are developed. A mountain lion is held as a pet? A raccoon is part of one of the parties? A lot of b-movie nonsense. Which is sad as the main takeaway of the film about race relations and the police actually works. Had this film developed characters and committed to its social message it could have ranked a lot higher. [Outlaw Biker Gang]

Tier 8: Avoid

82. **Angel Unchained:** An outlaw biker gang film from AIP, so even for a low-budget film it has ‘decent’ production values. The film wants to combine hippies and bikers, but does so in a way that does not exactly work. Mainly because there isn’t enough development of the hippies on the commune. The townsfolk are the villains of the film and they are cartoon villains which hurts the quality. Some of the dune buggy shots are nice, minus the fact the one hold the camera slips into the frame. The film isn’t generic slop, but it still checks off a lot of the genre boxes. [Outlaw Biker Gang]
81. **Alex in Wonderland:** Co-written and directed by Paul Mazursky (Bob & Carol & Ted & Alice) about a new hot-shot director trying to find a subject for his second film (*Alex* was also Paul’s second film). It takes a lot of swings, which result in a lot of misses. The film desires to reference the films of the French New Wave and Federico Fellini (Fellini even appears as himself! and the film often comes across as a parody of *8 1/2*—which I have yet to see; but the persistent references are not needed). There isn’t much of plot instead of series of vignettes. The war scene filmed on Hollywood Boulevard in front of Musso and Frank, almost works. As each scene wants to be a grand philosophical statement, yet they nearly all fall flat; often because the dialogue is bad. Donald Sutherland (*Joanna*) does not work as the lead and one wonders if he was cast because his long hippie hair fit the part. [Paul Mazursky]
80. **C.C. & Company:** An outlaw biker gang film led by Joe Namath (*Super Bowl III*). Namath is half-decent; he can deliver a cocky-yet-suave one-liner. But he cant do much else and often has a blank stare when not having to speak. Ann-Margret is his co-lead and one wonder why she slumped it in a film of this quality, other than the fact her husband wrote the script. The genre is now old enough that the film references a few of the earlier films, but keeps a lot of the requisite plot points the same. Other than seeing Joe Namath, the film does not offer much. [Outlaw Biker Gang]
79. **Ned Kelly:** Mick Jagger can not act. Asking him to be the lead in a film was a recipe for disaster, and guess what—the end result is a disaster. Directed by Tony Richardson (*Charge of the Light Brigade*), the direction is listless; starting with an awkward ‘The End’ to start the film of Kelly’s (fictional) hanging. Gerry Fisher’s (*Secret Ceremony*) is also listless and makes little use of the Australian outback. One wonders if everyone involved quickly knew a dud was on their hands and tried to get finished as quickly as possible. The only bright spot are the songs written by Shel Silverstein and performed by Waylon Jennings. The cast is scattershot, and therefore there is almost no character development and the action is often dull. [Mick Jagger]
78. **No Blade of Grass:** It seems like each list, has a movie that I can’t figure out how I added it, and this one is it (and usually these are all generally bad). An apocalyptic eco-thriller that really pushes its messages front and center. The first few minutes are taken up with shots of various sources of pollution, to really ensure the viewer gets the memo. After that it is nearly impossible to regain interest, but thankfully that doesn’t matter as the plot jumps around haphazardly. The film was adapted from a novel, and I can only assume the script attempted to include all of the plot points, meaning every new event occurs out of nowhere and is then over in three minutes to make time for the next encounter. There is no actual drama or tension because of the poorly paced script. The ending, ‘This isn’t a documentary but it could be’ is the rotten cherry on top of a bad movie. [No Idea]
77. **And Soon the Darkness:** A thriller/horror that is rarely thrilling or scary. The film wants to build tension over the disappearance of one of the English girls biking alone thru the French countryside. Yet each interaction with a new mysterious towns-person grows more tiring. The film wants the view to wonder which of the people could be responsible for the disappearance, but the tension is never there. Pamela Franklin (*The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie*) is decent, but cant do much with the material. It is partially the pacing, the (lack of) score, but the film as a whole comes together as bland. [Pamela Franklin]

76. **The People Next Door:** A film that wants to be about the generational divide at the time. Yet it is constantly let down by horrid writing and dialogue. I lost track of the times a teen would say, “Is that grass man?” and then an adult would get frustrated that there was smoking. Eli Wallach (*The Good, The Bad, and the Ugly*) over does it. It is one of Gordon Willis’ first films so he doesn’t bring much to the cinematography. The audience was adults, and the writer was an adult. The entire picture is out-of-touch and dated. [Gordon Willis]

Tier 7: The Tolerable B-Movies

75. **Cry of the Banshee:** The director’s cut of the film is version to watch as the animated opening credits (done by Terry Terry Gilliam would later go on to be a member of *Monty Python*) is quite nice, and sadly possibly the best part of the film. Director Gordon Hessler once again teams up with Vincent Price (*The Oblong Box*) for this AIP horror. Yet, this film has a predictable plot while being a bit too religious. It was never that interested in the witch hunts providing commentary on 1970 life. The sets and costumes are not that good (especially compared to the low-budget Hammer productions). The film is never bad (and why it can’t be a tier lower), but there are also rarely any bright spots either. [Horror]
74. **Wrath of the Wind (La collera del vento):** A spaghetti western led by Terrance Hill (*Boot Hill*) who’s charm is able to carry the film thru the various lulls and poorly constructed plot. It also helps that Maria Grazia Buccella is attractive in a supporting role. Yet, the two actors never nail their chemistry, which detracts from the one of the driving subplots. The politics of the farm-hand strike get heavy-handed and replaces needed character development. There is not that much bloodshed, relative to other genre entries. Also the film takes some geographic liberties and somehow the town is right next to the beach, but none of the establishing shots of the town show a beach anywhere to be seen. [Spaghetti Western]
73. **House of Dark Shadows:** Admittedly I have not seen a single episode of the TV series which is the basis for the movie. I gather watching the series would have made following the film a little easier, but one does not need to have seen the series. That the original series was a Soap Opera, can be seen in the film as the genre fluctuates wildly from horror to romance. Also, there are too many characters, which can be work in a TV show, but not in a ninety-minute movie (Wikipedia suggests nine different actors were temporarily written out of the show while filming the movie). Because of these assorted faults, the film is never able to get on solid footing. [Horror]
72. **Count Yorga, Vampire:** Not a Hammer Horror, but all it really adds tot he recent string of vampire movies is that it is set in modern-day Los Angeles. Outside of that, it proceeds how one would expect for the horrors of the era. There are some half-naked women running around, being turned into vampires. The plot itself is rather basic as the titular Count Yorga attempts to create a harem of vampire lovers. One of them eating their cat is creepy, I guess. But it is still done in a way that isn’t shocking beyond the idea of the eating one’s pet. It some ways the old-timey setting of the Hammer films allowed for more camp and funny costumes. This film simply doesn’t have much to offer. [Horror]
71. **The Out-of-Towners:** A genre of comedy I hate: the everything-goes-wrong-trip. As too often the problems are exogenous to the character’s actions; the flight is delayed, the flight is diverted, the train has no seats, the train has no food, etc. These are often items the character has no control over. Even attempts to endogenize the character’s problems are overblown or added in after-the-fact. Although there are some witty lines from writer Neil Simon (*Barefoot in the Park*), much of the humor does not land. Jack Lemmon (*The Odd Couple*) overdoes it and his character has no redeeming qualities, so one almost enjoys that his trip is ruined. Sandy Dennis (*Who’s Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*) is given enough to do, and by the second-half of the film she is phoning in her lines in the most shrill

voice imaginable. Also, the film is anti-NYC, which as a personal preference I can not stand. People who prefer living in small town Ohio over NYC should be mocked. [Golden Globes – Best Actor in a Comedy Nominee]

70. **Scars of Dracula:** The first Hammer Dracula film on the list, but it was the second in release order. The film undoes some of the continuity of the yet-to-be-ranked previous film. The film adds little to the series, beyond Dracula's servant showing a willingness to betray his master. There are multiple mismatched shots both going from on-location to sets and going from night to 'night'. The film reuses a fair bit of standard Dracula plot points, and makes more use of bats than previous films. The film is never laughably cheap and bad, but it lacks the enjoyability of previous Hammer films. [Horror]
69. **The Dunwich Horror:** Another AIP horror, this one adapted from an H.P. Lovecraft story. The direction from Daniel Haller (*Devil's Angels*) is better than one would expect, the colored negative-image shots at night are one of the nicer touches. Yet, the script is often bad. The liners are cheesy and clunky. Sandra Dee adds little and often phones in her performance, whereas Dean Stockwell (*Psych-Out*) tries his best, given the poor dialogue. For a B-horror this had a few nice touches, but not enough to bring it home. [Horror]
68. **Beneath the Planet of the Apes:** The first half of the film is a lower-budget version of the version, with similar plot points. Though it does develop the militaristic side of the Apes. Perhaps if Charlton Heston was more interested in the franchise, it could have been greatly improved. As once the 'new' human gets beneath the surface, and discovers the subway tracks, the film goes off the rails. And so far off the rails the film can't be saved. The second half is bad, and not campy-enough to work. The second half is also a bad impression of far better films. I will not spoil it, as it needs to be seen to be believed how much the mangled the franchise. [Sequel]
67. **The Horror of Frankenstein:** The film starts out developing the character of Victor Frankenstein as a snot-nosed, horny, know-it-all, and Ralph Bates does a solid job of camping it up. Yet, once he starts his experiments the film starts to lose its luster. The film isn't that scary, and the monster isn't that good-looking (or should I say bad-looking?). The cast features some Hammer regulars such as Kate O'Mara and Veronica Carlson. Had it realized how fun the first thirty minutes was, and leaned into that campy energy the film would rank far higher. [Horror]
66. **Hornets' Nest:** A run-of-the-mill WWII film. Rock Hudson (*Tobruk*) isn't good enough to carry the film, it seems that he is collecting a paycheck with this one. If anything the best character is the Nazi officer played by Sergio Fantoni as the only one who knows that the looming attack is going to occur. The character also has a level of respect for the enemy and military strategy. Had the film been better, it would have explored that character development more. The children/teens are mainly forgettable and the leader of the group isn't given enough development so the main changes end up feeling forced. The entire female doctor character does not work at all, and the character constantly flips between stereotypical tropes. Ennio Morricone does the score, and it also seems like he took the paycheck as well. [Rock Hudson]
65. **Crimes of the Future:** David Cronenberg's (*Stereo*) second low-budget film. The brief (just over 60 minutes) film, has all sound added in post and that does detract from the film as there is no dialogue, only voice overs and some (at-times) disturbing musical cues. Although it shows how to craft a film that doesn't look cheap on a minuscule budget, the film itself doesn't work. Though one can see some of Cronenberg's style coming thru: with the webbed toes and the very-creepy scenes with the little girl. One almost wishes there was a budget to make the film properly, as the ideas are all there. Yet the final product does not work. [David Cronenberg]

Tier 6: Bland or Not-Good With a Redeeming Quality

64. **Beyond the Valley of the Dolls:** A sorta unapproved sequel to *Valley of the Dolls*. The problem with this film, is that it wants to be a sexy parody of the first. Yet the first was so-bad-its-good, which makes it harder to parody. The first movie was so bad you'd laugh at the dialogue and the delivery. And so when trying to parody that, the laughs are not the same, even though they are there in the script from Roger Ebert (*criticizing your favorite movie*). There are lots of boobs and softcore sex. The plot is bonkers, and the leading ladies (at least two of whom are former Playboy Playmates) are not exactly chosen for their acting talents. John LaZar is decent as the campy record producer. For all these negatives, the soundtrack, which features a mix of original songs and some from Strawberry Alarm Clock, is rather good. [Sequel, Sorta]
63. **Adiós, Sabata (Indio Black, sai che ti dico: Sei un gran figlio di...):** Technically a *Sabata* film as it is directed by Gianfranco Parolini and the lead character in the English version is named Sabata. Yet, as the Italian title implies, the character was really named Indio Black and only changed to Sabata to make more money. And most of all, 'Sabata' is played by Yul Brynner and not Lee Van Cleef. Brynner brings a more subdued energy to the role (ala Arnold in the *Terminator* franchise), yet the first worked so well because of Van Cleef's mischievousness. This film has a few too many characters which complicates a simple gold-stealing plot. Some of the superfluous characters have strange ways of killing such as kicking lead balls. The campiness doesn't exactly work (again maybe with Van Cleef it could). There are a few interesting kills, especially with a painting and model gun boat. Yet too much of the film is standard, even if one is able to distance it from the franchise. [Spaghetti Western]
62. **Matalo! (Kill Him):** An art house Spaghetti Western. The score is psychedelic rock, which sometimes work. The costumes are out of hippie culture, which sometimes work. The editing is frantic and scatter-shot, which sometimes work. The camera spins and flies through the air, which sometimes work. One appreciates that the film is unlike many other Spaghetti Westerns; there is minimal dialogue, the plot is scant. When it works, the film is gorgeously shot, with interesting editing. When it doesn't work, the film bogs down and becomes a slog even at slightly over ninety minutes. [Spaghetti Western]
61. **They Call Me Mister Tibbs!:** A sequel no one asked for. They take Sidney Poitier's classic character and film into a routine who-dun-it now set in San Francisco (ignoring that he worked in Philly during the first film). The film frequently feels like a middling episode of CSI. Even Ed Asner (*The Mary Tyler Moore Show*) and Martin Landau as the various suspects can't bring much to the film. There are also side plots with Tibb's family, which are not needed and add almost nothing to the plot. Unlike other films in this tier, it is rarely bad, but rather it also lacks any good or memorable moments. [Sequel]
60. **The Virgin and The Gypsy:** The first of two films adapted from D.H. Lawrence novels, and much like the looming review, a large chunk of my issue is the source material. Set in late-Victorian Era, the film wishes to make comparisons to the rebellion against sexual and societal norms then to the upheaval of now (or at least I hope so, otherwise what is even the purpose of making the film? the characters are not that interesting). But when a plot point is a family forbidding the titular daughter from seeing a couple, where the women is getting a divorce from another man, and the current man lives with her! This situation does not come across as dramatic but cheesy. Joanna Shimkus (*Boom!*) and France Nero (*Django*) are both attractive but their acting cant capture the viewers attention and overcome the multiple lulls in the plot. These British films do not do it for me. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film]
59. **Darling Lili:** A musical comedy espionage film that doesn't work as a musical (the songs and numbers aren't very good and feel like a relic of the 1950s), nor does it work as a comedy as the jokes rarely land while the visual gags aren't funny and often directed poorly. And the espionage isn't

thrilling. It only works as a love story between the characters of Julie Andrews (*Thoroughly Modern Millie*) and Rock Hudson (*Ice Station Zebra*). Julie Andrews at least tries, while Rock Hudson does not give it much effort. The pair of French detectives are suppose to be the main comedic characters and they do not provide much comedy. The aerial shots pale in comparison to those in *Tora!*. The entire film feels like a relic of the 1950s. [Oscars – Best Costumes Nominee]

58. **Cromwell:** A slog of a biopic that is too long and tries to cover too much ground. It has the classic failure of a singular scene to establish the latest motivation instead of having a slow change in character. The battle scenes are not exciting or innovating; the only good shot was briefly under a horse. I didn't think the costumes were anything special, though perhaps their drabness was historically accurate? The sets were decent, but the production values didn't blow me away. Alec Guinness is good as King Charles. Robert Morley (*Hot Millions*) is also decent in a small role. Also of note is a young Timothy Dalton. Except the film never quite comes together to make Oliver Cromwell a compelling character. [Oscars – Best Costume Design]
57. **Have a Good Funeral, My Friend... Sartana Will Pay (Buon funerale amigos!... paga Sartana):** The second *Sartana* film released in 1970, and the first with the standard lead of Gianni Garko (*Vengeance Is Mine*). The film keeps most of the wit, but not as much. There are a few inventive kills, such as the accounting book. The card throwing is a bit too cheesy to work, and also gets repetitive. Daniela Giordano is 'good' as the female lead, in that she was a former Miss Italy winner and her acting is tolerable. The Chinese casino owner does not work as a character (at least played by a Taiwanese person), as far too many of his lines are, "Confucius says..." By the second time the joke was worn out its welcome, yet it continues. The film is still enjoyable and fun, but inferior to others in the franchise. [Spaghetti Western]
56. **Tora! Tora! Tora!:** The film functions more like a documentary than an actual film. Far too many characters are introduced and almost none of them are developed. Why a character passes along information, or decided not to, is a spur-of-the-moment decision and often by a character the audience has just met. The pre-intermission action is often dull and saved mainly by the film's VFX. As the models often look rather good, and the 'action' outside of officer's windows is realistic. Once the bombing begins, the action look goods. Yet, it rarely develops any tension. It often feels like a Japanese-American remake of *The Battle of Britain*, both in terms of lacking character development and relying on production values. As the production values are so high, some of the errors can be forgiven, but the film is still straight forward without character development or tension. [Oscars – Best VFX]
55. **Julius Caesar:** There is exactly one good thing about the film: Charlton Heston's (*The Planet of the Apes*) speech as Marc Antony after Caesar's death. Heston knows how to give a Shakespearean monologue. Jason Robards (*Once Upon a Time in the West*) phones in his performance as Brutus. His delivery lacks any inflection and feels like he is reading the lines of a piece of paper he was just handed off-screen. Most of the sets look cheap (especially the staircase where the major speeches are delivered). The film is a massive miss. [Great Cast]
54. **Ryan's Daughter:** A film which would rank in the next tier, if it wasn't for the film's primary flaw: it is three-and-a-half hours long. Even with an intermission at almost exactly halfway, the entire film is frequently a chore and rarely needs to be that long. David Lean (*Lawrence of Arabia*) might have had successes with long epics before, but here the characters are not rich enough to require more than two hours of screen time. Even if 'The Troubles' in Northern Ireland were heating up, that conflict is shoe-horned into the the WWI setting of the film and rarely adds depth to the film that holds up in the current day. The film also fails to realize that Robert Mitchum's character is gay, which would have made for a more dramatic film given the plot is the affair his wife has with a British officer. Maurice Jarre's score is a bit too weird at times. Thankfully Freddie Young's

cinematography is absolutely gorgeous, even if the plot becomes a chore and overly long, every few minutes there is a beautifully composed shot that nearly makes the film watchable again. Sarah Miles (*Blow Up*) is good, but not great. John Miles (*The Family Way*) seems to have been given a lifetime achievement Oscar despite not taking Kirk Lazarus' (*Tropic Thunder*) advice. Even what is an excellently composed and edited climax, falls flat emotionally because the film does not really work. [Oscars – Best Cinematography]

Tier 5: Enough Good to Overcome the Bad, or Not Enough Bad to Weigh Down the Lack of Good; Meh

53. **The Clowns (I Clowns):** A psuedo-documentary/mockumentary from Federico Fellini (*Fellini Satyricon*) who (meta) style does not exactly work. The two fiction sequences which bookend the film are funny and often work (clowns are funny after all). Yet the middle forty-ish minutes of interviews and 'documentary' work rarely work (I am also not a fan of documentaries to begin with). Perhaps if the meta commentary on filmmaking lands one can enjoy the film a bit more, but its a chore sandwiched between two lengthy clown performances featuring solid camera work. [Fellini]

52. **The Unholy Four (Ciakmull (L'uomo della vendetta)):** A Spaghetti Western that works best with the Italian name, as the film is not exactly about the four escaped prisoners but rather only one of them; Chuck Mool, played by Leonard Mann (who isn't near the quality of the 'A-List' leading men of the genre). The plot becomes a bit bonkers, with one too many twists. Yet the visuals are often good, especially the opening prison fire (and escape); the film was directed by cinematographer-turned-director Enzo Barboni (*Django*). The score by Riz Ortolani has a theme which absolutely slaps (the parts that are not the theme are not as good, so the theme gets repeated a lot, but its so good, you are happy to hear it a tenth time). One wishes the supporting characters of the 'titular' four were more developed, but the film works for the part. [Spaghetti Western]

51. **Taste the Blood of Dracula:** The fourth Dracula film in the Hammer series. Ralph Bates (*The Horror of Frankenstein*) is delightful in his brief role as a follower of Dracula. The film primary succeeds as it makes the viewer root for Dracula as he seeks his revenge on three wealthy Brits (who end up summoning him as they are quickly running out of kinky ways to get their perverted rocks off). The brothel scene alone allows the film to rank a tier higher. Despite being the fourth in the franchise, it finds a unique path. And of course Christopher Lee is enjoyable as always. [Horror]

50. **Scream and Scream Again:** Another AIP horror directed by Gordon Hessler (*Cry of the Banshee*) that breaks out a trio of classic b-horror actors: Christopher Lee, Vincent Price, and Peter Cushing; in rough order of the screen time. The film's plot is a tad absurd and sprawling, but if one embraces the b-movie, the plot ends up working. The mystery is kept up for most of the film. The car chase is excellent directed, especially for a low-budget film (even if a few shots are mismatched on what roads are being traveled). There are also multiple shots making use of mirrors (including the review mirror during the car chase. For a b-movie, this has some excellent touches to elevate it. [Horror]

49. **Scrooge:** Albert Finney (*Two for the Road*) plays the titular Scrooge, and he can't exactly nail the old miser. He does excel when playing the the reformed Scrooge (and often tries to set up the transformation, especially when drinking with the Spirit of Christmas Present). The makeup for Finney is really good as he was only 35 during film, as was an attractive leading man. The songs are essentially forgettable. Also for being just under two hours, the film still drags as most every Spirit has one extra scene which wasn't needed. The 'stargate' sequence to Hell was laughably bad. How one views the cheerful ending, will probably reflect the overall view of the film. As the ending works (even if long), Finney really gives Scrooge a quirky redemption that makes you feel good. But it can't save the lows before hand. [Oscars – Best Art Direction Nominee]

48. **Husbands:** Written, directed, and starring John Cassavetes (*Faces*). The film is overly long and two-hours-and-twenty-minutes. And apparently he already cut over an hour from it. The issue is too much time is spent on actors talking with each other, with nothing of importance happening in the scene. The film wanted to be a grand treatise on male friendship, life/death, and marriage. Yet the jokes rarely land, the ‘dramatic’ moments drag on for too long. The ideas are all there, but execution is lacking. The film becomes almost a chore at times. [Golden Globes – Best Screenplay Nominee]
47. **The AristoCats:** Possibly the definition of a ‘meh’ Disney animated film. The animation itself is a bit sloppy at times, but never awful. The plot and characters often feels like a *Jungle Book* re-hash; Phil Harris and Sterling Holloway do voice work in both (and a few would go onto to voice work in *Robin Hood*). The plot and characters often feels like a *101 Dalmatians* re-hash, with needing to get the pets back home and the sound effects of old puttering engines. ‘Ev’rybody Wants to Be a Cat’ does a fair in saving the film from ranking in the lower tier. The film starts the slow decent after the post-war revival into mediocrity before the 90s renaissance. [Disney]
46. **Hatchet for the Honeymoon (Il rosso segno della follia):** A giallo that I could only get an English-language dub, which detracts a bit (mainly because one can often tell they weren’t recorded on set. And partially because I like using the original audio to learn Italian). Written, directed and with cinematography by Mario Brava, his script is probably the worst of the three (the cinematography is decent, but not good enough to continually wow you; the body on the staircase is one of the best shots). As we know who the killer is almost instantly, and his ‘evasion’ of the policy is rarely witty sans one well-timed movie on TV. The bridal gowns are decent, but one wish they were better given (as the English-language title alludes to) that brides are being murdered. It all combines for a mediocre giallo. [Giallo]
45. **Sartana’s Here... Trade Your Pistol for a Coffin (C’è Sartana... vendi la pistola e comprati la bara):** The third film in the *Sartana* franchise (and the first of three released in 1970), and the only one with George Hilton as the titular bounty hunter. Although he is no Gianni Garko, he manages to play the role rather well, as the key with any *Sartana* film is the cunning and intelligence the character uses to outwit opponents. Though this film does get a tad repetitive (so much bread-based killing), it keeps the wit and even adds a foil to Sartana in Sabata (not from the *Sabata* franchise) played by Charles Southwood who has great chemistry with Hilton. This is not a serious film, but it knows it is not serious. Instead it leans into the fun and manages to work even if there might seem to be too many characters and too much double-crossing. [Spaghetti Western]
44. **The Vampire Lovers:** An enjoyable b-movie horror from Hammer, that became a cult classic for a reason. It has the hallmarks of Hammer Productions; especially the gothic sets and Peter Cushing (*Frankenstein Must Be Destroyed*) in a small role. The plot could have been fleshed out a little bit more, with some more motivation for the main vampire played by Ingrid Pitt (*Where Eagles Dare*), beyond vampires suck blood and this one is a lesbian. The portrayal of lesbians isn’t exactly perfect but that a film was daring to be so bold is nice (even if at times it feels a tad exploitative, given the frequency with which the various female actors appear topless). Madeline Smith and Kate O’Mara are decent as well; none of the actors are amazing, but that the movie avoids poorly-delivered dialogue is a major plus. The film is exactly what you want from a b-movie horror. [Hammer Horror]
43. **Waterloo:** The film has little interest in character development; especially the main generals of Napoleon and Wellington. Neither Rod Steiger (*In the Heat of the Night*) nor Christopher Plummer (*Battle of Britain*) bring much to their characters as well, given how little they are developed. Yet, the film – especially the battle scenes – are so lavish and grandiose it can rank here. The sheer size of the battle, and costumed extras is a spectacle to behold. The editing of the battle could be better, and it could ratchet up the tension more. Yet, at the end of the day, the sheer scale makes it a tolerable watch. [BAFTA – Best Costumes]

42. **Zabriskie Point:** Co-written and directed by Michelangelo Antonioni (*Blow-Up*). Sometimes the view of an outsider provides new insights, but the renowned Italian directors first (and only) American production about American culture in the 60s does not work. The opening organization of a protest by college students has pitiful dialogue and the jerky cutting camera tries to give a documentary feel only adds to how out of touch the sequence feels (whereas the boys buying firearms illegally under the guise of protecting their (white) women from the ‘neighbors’ works). The film purpose avoids showing much of the confrontations between students and cops, and that is a decision which hampers the film even if some of the bloody aftermath is shown. In addition to bad dialogue the two leads were cast as unknown and they are completely incapable of carrying a film, let alone an ambitious art house production (Mark Frechette is the worst of the two by a wide margin). Yet, the cinematography is often gorgeous, especially everything shot in Death Valley and the titular Zabriskie Point (well, maybe not the orgy in Death Valley). Great directors are often great because they take risks, yet this is another example of a risk that fell flat. [Michelangelo Antonioni]
41. **Two Mules for Sister Sara:** A standard-enough western, that only works because Clint Eastwood and Shirley MacLaine (*Sweet Charity*) are Movie Stars. Director Don Siegel (*Coogan’s Bluff*) is a competent director, and the on-location filming in Mexico is often well-done. However the script overdoes the nun character for plot points and comedy bits. The film itself doesn’t need to be nearly two hours (a ‘domestic’ cut trims about ten minutes, but I watched the full version). Everyone combines to be competent at their job, yet the end product is a film that merely exists. [Clint Eastwood]
40. **Santa Claus is Comin’ to Town:** Isn’t this a fifty-minute TV special? Yes. But I make the rules. If fifty minutes can be a feature in the silent era, it can be now. Get in the spirit of Christmas you filthy animals! Rankin/Bass is a classic animation studio so I can include them. The stop-motion here is decent, some parts are nice others look iffy. The voice cast is solid especially as Fred Astaire being the narrator is a perfect choice and Paul Frees is a voice-acting all-timer. ‘No More Toymakers to the King’ is a great Christmas song while ‘Put One Foot in Front of the Other’ is great regardless the season, though some of the other originals fall flat. The ending gets a bit religious to hold up as well as it could given the secularization of Christmas. [Rankin/Bass]
39. **Hi, Mom!:** Technically a sequel to *Greetings!* with Robert De Niro reprising his character and Brian De Palma also writing and directing. Yet one would not really recognize it as a sequel. The film is too disjoint with two separate plots in the eighty-minute runtime; the voyeurism sex films and the black acting troupe. The acting troupe should be the better sequence, but given the framing of the film around De Niro’s character, it does not fit in nicely to the plot (despite De Niro initially spying on the troupe and then joining their performance as a cop; De Niro is great as the cop). The film needed to only focus on the acting troupe with De Niro as a supporting actor. There are good ideas here, but they don’t all come together. If anything, the film is best viewed as a lead up to the forces that would culminate in *Taxi Driver*. [Brian De Palma]
38. **Bed and Board (Domicile conjugal):** The third feature film about the character of Antoine Doinel from François Truffaut. The review from *Stolen Kisses* could almost be copied word-for-word, as it leans into the worst parts of the previous film while the camerawork is not nearly as good. Once again we are left to wonder how women keep falling for Antoine, while Claude Jade’s character isn’t given enough room to shine (all while her parents still love Antoine). A reoccurring joke with a character asking to borrow money never works and becomes grating. The film rarely gets into bad territory, but frequently falls flat—especially relative to the previous entries in the series. [François Truffaut]
37. **Women in Love:** A romantic drama set in late-Victorian Era England, these films rarely do it for him as the pacing is never good and I am unable to care about the class differences. To make matters

worse, the characters in this film are addicted to discussing the nature of love (though this might be a result of the D.H. Lawrence source material). The endless chatter combined with director Ken Russell's love of visual motifs, make a large chunk of the film a chore to get through. Thankfully, the leading actors are all good: Alan Bates (*Georgy Girl*), Oliver Reed (*Oliver!*), Jennie Linden, and the star of the film Glenda Jackson (*Marat/Sade*). Jackson is the best of the bunch, with Bates the runner up. Though Jackson probably did not deserve to win the Oscar. The film does incorporate nudity in a more artistic way than the cheap exploitation films which added tits to get eyeballs, and the wrestling scene is a breakthrough. The film also pushes the envelope regarding sexuality, and relationships, but the film never comes together in a fully coherent manner. [Oscars – Best Actress]

36. **Light the Fuse... Sartana Is Coming (Una nuvola di polvere... un grido di morte... arriva Sartana):** Third and final *Sartana* film released this year (and the final film in the series). The film has everything one wants from the franchise; with crazy gadgets and weapons and double-crossing abound. The tikihead might be the best gadget in the entire series, as it is such a simple and fun way of delivering death. The pipe organ works perfectly. Franco Pesce again appears as the bumbling inventor and card shark and really brings a crazy sensibility to the franchise. Lots of people are outsmarted and killed. It is a fun end to the franchise. [Spaghetti Western]
35. **The Twelve Chairs:** Written and directed by Mel Brooks, the film isn't as funny as one would hope. The best gags involve the various Bureaus of Furniture. Otherwise, the actors aren't able to bring much comedy especially Dom DeLuise and Ron Moody (*Oliver!*) who often overact without comedic effect. Thankfully Frank Langella provides enough charm to keep the film interesting. But this is squarely a lesser effort from Mel Brooks [WGA – Best Comedy Nominee]
34. **Airport:** The long list of A-list actors combined with excellent production design help (partially) elevate this early disaster film. As the film has a few too many plot holes, the biggest being, if an airplane has a hole blown in the side of it... land at the nearest airport! Do not fly over an hour back to the departure airport! Maureen Stapleton is the best actor of the bunch, despite George Kennedy having a grand ol time. Jacqueline Bisset (*Bullitt*) is good (and attractive) as her character provides a fair bit of the drama. The film touches on a lot of social issues; abortion, suicide, divorce, but rarely gets too deep into any of the issues. Perhaps the most fun watching is seeing the origin of many of the gags in *Airplane!*. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]

Tier 4: Well-Made American Films and a Few Italians

33. **Multiple Maniacs:** This trash could easily be in a lower tier as the semi-disconnected bits often drag on; a single good joke ends up spanning five minutes instead of one. And give the film is only 95 minutes, it still manages to drag. Speaking of drag, Divine is good in the leading role as is possibly the least 'shocking' aspect of the film. John Waters' script is timely with references to Sharon Tate's murder and the Weather Underground. Though its two best(?) moments are one involving a rosary and another with a lobster. The movie is cheaply made (as seen by the opening credits), which helps for the most part (but an actual budget probably helps the film thru the lulls) and the rest of the cast is more than capable, especially David Lochary. It is a wonderful historic artifact, but as a film it doesn't quite come together like one would hope. [John Waters]
32. **Puzzle of a Downfall Child:** The script by Carole Eastman (*The Shooting*) is good, but also lets the film down. As the film is too sporadic with few moments spelled out enough. As the film could be that the main character was sexually abused as a teen and carried that guilt with her, or that she was the one making sexual advances at a young age which created issues with her own self-worth (either of which would explain the character's mental breakdown; it is the 70s after all, the breakdown has to require a lot of hospitalization). Faye Dunaway is very good as the lead, and keeps the film interesting thru the lulls because she is that talented. Had the film been less opaque

with its leading character it could have ranked a little higher, though the scatter-shot remembrances could easily move it down a tier as well. [Golden Globes – Best Actress in a Drama Nominee]

31. **Cotton Comes to Harlem:** An early blaxploitation film, and it works. The costumes are all rather good. The on-location filming in Harlem is nice. The opening car chase is decent. Godfrey Cambridge and Raymond St. Jacques as the lead detectives are so good together and deliver the witty and comedic lines perfectly. Their chemistry along with the writing elevate the film to this tier. The plot nearly veers into absurdity, but manages to avoid crossing that line. It also does a decent job of threading that exploitation line, where the various race-relations are not in-your-face, but lingering in the background until plot elements require them. [Blaxploitation]
30. **The Kremlin Letter:** An espionage ‘thriller’, co-written and directed by John Huston (*The Maltese Falcon*) the film bounces around in quality. Too often it gets bogged down in code names and identity changes. The MacGuffin of the titular Kremlin Letter isn’t strong enough to start and advance the plot. There are enough twists and turns to keep the plot engaging though, but it is never thrilling enough to keep the audience guessing. Richard Boone (*Hombre*) is rather good as the veteran spy and probably deserved a Best Support Actor nomination. The film does come together by the end, but again too much tries to happen before hand. Also, of particular annoyance, is that the ‘Russian’ scenes often start in Russian, with an overdub of English, before transitioning to English. Once can see why this was done, but it does not exactly work, especially as the film repeats the process multiple times. [John Huston]
29. **And God Said to Cain (E Dio disse a Caino):** The premise of this Spaghetti Western is a simple one of revenge on the man who falsely imprisoned the lead and then taken of the local town for his own enrichment. Nothing new with plots and characters is done. Rather the slow building of suspense from director Antonio Margheriti with Klaus Kinski (*The Great Silence*) as the man out for revenge make the film work. The looming storm about to hit the town provides the necessary backdrop for empty streets and allows Kinski’s character to pick off the henchmen one-by-one using tunnels/old Indian cemetery below the town. The deaths are also great with two excellent bell-related deaths. The town was shot at Elios Studio (*Django*) which also adds a nice touch of nostalgia. The climax in a mirrored room is beautifully shot. For a plot that’s been used a million times, the film still finds ways to expand the genre. [Spaghetti Western]
28. **The Call Me Trinity (Lo chiamavano Trinit’a...):** A comedic Spaghetti Western, which excels thanks to Terence Hill (*Ace High*) and Bud Spencer (*Boot Hill*). Hill has the time of his life playing Trinity, with such a devil-may-care nonchalance that comes across as pure charm. Hill hams it up, and it entirely works. Spencer’s more brooding character is a great foil. And the two have great chemistry and Farley Granger is good as the villain trying to get the Mormons to leave their land. The Mormons anti-violence approach is ripe for comedy and sets up the film’s climatic fight scene. Even as Spaghetti Westerns started to run out of ideas, there is always gold in mining quality laughs. [Spaghetti Western]
27. **The Forbidden Photos of a Lady Above Suspicion (Le foto proibite di una signora per bene):** A sexy blackmail giallo, that dials up the going-crazy thrills with thanks to a solid score from Ennio Morricone. Dagmar Lassander is good in the leading role as the blackmailed wife of a shady businessman, likewise her friend played by Nieves Navarro (*The Big Gundown*) is good as well (they both bring the sex appeal as expected from the genre). The costumes are rather nice. The ‘empty’ apartment, the lights cutting out, among others are great examples of the psychological tension. [Giallo]
26. **The Owl and the Pussycat:** An amusing romantic comedic held together by a decent script and the always-delightful Barbra Streisand (*Funny Girl*) and George Segal (*Who’s Afraid of Virginia Woolf?*). Streisand’s delivery is perfect and she probably turns a few unfunny lines into something

worth a chuckle. Likewise Segal's plays the nerdy 'Owl' rather well as a foil to Streisand's brash sex-worker character. The first two acts drag a bit as the confined to a single location each, as that's where the source play hurts a little; it is hard to developed the chaotic energy when the characters a 'stuck' in two different apartments. There are still enough laughs to make the film enjoyable. [Golden Globes – Best Actress in a Comedy Nominee]

25. **Sunflower (I girasoli):** Directed by Vittorio Di Sica (*Woman Times Seven*) the film is held together by two solid performances by Sophia Loren (*Arabesque*) and Marcello Mastroianni. The two provide the love, loss, longing, and regret needed to carry the film. The direction isn't choppy, but not every choice works; i.e. the winter war scenes overlaid with a waving red flag initial work, but then carries on too long. The time line is also a bit confusing (though perhaps Italian audiences from then were more familiar with the plight of missing soldiers in Russia after WWII). Despite these flaws, the film is still a solid character drama/romance (that at times make make one wish they were watching *Casablanca*) with two solid leading performances. [Oscars – Best Score Nominee]
24. **Lovers and Other Strangers:** A romantic comedy adapted from a stage play. The adaptation is evident as characters pair off to have their own scenes. Only during the wedding, does the film cross-cut between the characters (a little more cross-cutting would have improved the film). There are some jokes (the elder Italian couple's pitter-patter is the best), but they are not quite plentiful. The film is more interested in the changing norms around marriage, divorce, and sex; most of which come off as a little dated. The cast is rather stacked with talent: Beatrice Arthur, Bonnie Bedelia, Richard Castellano, Marian Hailey, Cloris Leachman, and the film debut of Diane Keaton. There are no major faults, but there are a few places the film could have improved. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actor Nominee]
23. **Compañeros:** Directed by Sergio Corbucci (*The Great Silence*) the film is a great late-era Spaghetti Western; combining comedy and politics. Whereas the other more political films are in your face, this film uses its humor to give the politics a more tongue-in-cheek feel at times (for example when cracking the safe). Franco Nero (*The Mercenaries*) and Thomas Milian (*Run, Man, Run*) are great as the leads and work off each so well; Nero's suave confidence contrasts with Milain's bumbling well-intentions. Oh and Jack Palance (*The Professionals*) plays a creepy villain. The jokes land, and Corbucci's direction is excellent as always (a few shots with mirrors and some excellent framing including one with Milain's character tied up to a bed frame). Plus it has the proper amount of gratuitous violence. There are more character-driven Spaghetti Westerns, and one that are more innovative, but few as funny. [Spaghetti Western]
22. **Rio Lobo:** The last film directed by Howard Hawks (*El Dorado*), led by a late-career John Wayne. The film itself becomes difficult to rank at times, because it often feels like a relic of Old Hollywood; the 'stars' at the campsite are the worst offender (and most night-time scenes are obviously shot on a soundstage). The dialogue is often old-fashioned, but also at times has that old-time charm (e.g. Mr. Nobody). Likewise character actor Jack Elam (*Support Your Local Sheriff!*) hams it up nicely. The plot isn't quite a revisionist Western like the few westerns still to come on the list (or that were being made in the US that previous few years), yet the women are useful characters and even kill a person or two (Jennifer O'Neill (*For Love of Ivy*) being good in a supporting role). It is fitting a classic Old Hollywood director's final film still feels old, but at least manages to include a few modern touches. [Howard Hawks]
21. **Diary of a Mad Housewife:** The primary issue with the film is that although it tries to be progressive about housewives being neglected and causing them to have affairs, it really hammers home the mistreatment. By the second time the husband yells out, "Tiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiiina" the audience has had enough. Yet it continues as if it is developing characters. This holds the film back from breaking into the next tier. The three main characters are all very good: Carrie Snodgress, Richard

Benjamin (*Goodbye, Columbus*), and Frank Langella (*The Twelve Chairs*). Each of those three give these characters depth (even if Benjamin has the least to work with), and being from the perspective of the housewife and her sex life greatly improves the film (Frank Langella gives a few passionate speeches about the quality of the sex in their fling). The film makes the audience feel for the trapped housewife in such a way that films were just starting to portray. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee]

20. **Kelly's Heroes:** A World War II caper-comedy, that often works. The film is able to combine some zaniness with satirical commentary on the Vietnam War (a scene features a US plane shooting at the American battalion). Clint Eastwood (*Where Eagles Dare*) is top-billed, but doesn't need to do much but provide star power (and play a character who would try to steal a bunch of German gold for his own enrichment). The supporting cast provides a bunch of comedy as well with Don Rickles, Carroll O'Connor (would play *Archie Bunker*), and Gavin MacLeod (would be in *The Mary Tyler Moore Show*). O'Connor as the general is the best of the three *All for the Love of Sunshine* is a solid song and helps the movie out as well. Yet for all of these positive aspects the film ends up being Donald Sutherland's (*The Dirty Dozen*). Sutherland probably deserved a Supporting Actor nomination. His nonchalance and laid-back attitude captures the spirit of the 70s and aids the satire. Perhaps the biggest issue is that the previous mentioned movies: *The Dirty Dozen* and *Where Eagles Dare* are both better. [Clint Eastwood]
19. **Something for Everyone:** Is at times too long and often not as funny as it should have been (the print I saw didn't have the best audio though). Directed by Harold Prince in his film debut, and he didn't really seem able to make the jump to the big screen from Broadway as the camerawork could have been better. Michael York (*Romeo and Juliet*) is devilishly charming in the leading role; even if Angela Lansbury is top-billed and decent herself. Jane Carr (*The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie*) is a delight as always as the daughter. Where the film excels is that it is willing to go there in 1970; both with murders and sex. York's character jumping from bed to bed is great. And the audience is left to wonder what is pure manipulation versus sexual appetite. [Golden Globe – Best Actress in a Comedy Nominee]

Tier 3: New Hollywood in Full Force

18. **The Honeymoon Killers:** A low-budget film shot in gorgeous black and white, even if at times one ends up wishing they were watching *In Cold Blood* instead. The film does a great job of building up the lead characters (though the major flaw is that they never quite explain why Ray stays with Martha as it isn't clear she adds to his cons). The film keeps the murders nonchalant, and instead keeps the focus on why each occurred. That the murders are not accidents or the work of brutal savages, but simply jealous people who are scared of getting caught. That the murders are character-driven makes the movie hum. The sound quality is iffy at times and can detract from the film, though there is an argument it adds to the atmosphere. [Well-reviewed Drama]
17. **Brewster McCloud:** The first film by Robert Altman on the list, though the second in chronological release order. The film is zany and often comedic. Though there are so many gags and oddities, it at times feels as if they are throwing things at the wall and seeing what sticks (a fair bit of the jokes land, but there are so many that some get missed). The film tries to parody a bunch of things, while also subtly getting the desire to be free vs settling down and with wanting to fight the system. The entire cast is rather good, a chunk of which were holdovers from *MASH*: René Auberjonois, Michael Murphy, and Sally Kellerman. The film is notable for being the debut of Shelley Duvall. This is one of the more unique films of the year; even when it gets too zany and things do not land one still appreciates the risks. [Robert Altman]
16. **Performance:** A gorgeous but uneven crime film. The first half is a gangster film previewing what was to come with *The Godfather*, carried by an absolutely charming James Fox (*Isadora*), despite

playing a blood-thirsty gangster. Whereas the second-half of the film when his characters hides away in an rowhome owned by Mick Jagger (*Ned Kelly*) there is a massive tonal shift to sex and drugs which the film does not fully pull off. Mick Jagger's 'acting' is a main reason it doesn't work (yet there is a hallucinogenic musical number and the audience instantly remembers why Jagger is one of the greatest rock stars of all time; it really is a jarring transition), whereas first-time co-director's Nicolas Roeg's (*Petulia*) cinematography helps to make it work. The green lighting, the intricate camera angles (often making use of a mirrored ceiling), the full-length hinged mirror makes for some beautiful shots. The themes of the second half around identity are not fully developed. As much as the film would have been improved by replacing Jagger, his presence meant the studio never checked in on the production letting Donald Cammell and Nicolas Roeg make a beautiful semi-experimental film. [BAFTA – Best Editing Nominee]

15. **Love Story:** Is it hokey? Yes. Does it drag? Yes. Does it actually deserve to be in this tier? Ehhhh. Would I rather rewatch it before all the other films in this tier? Most likely. Was I an emotional mess at the end? No comment. Ali MacGraw (*Goodbye, Columbus*) is completely captivating and plays an actual character and not just a love interest (evn if as the film goes on the gender roles revert to the standard). Likewise a young Ryan O'Neal is equally charming. John Marley (*Faces*) nearly steals every scene he's in as her father. The MG TC car is beaut and gives the film the perfect amount of old-money charm. Arthur Hiller's (*The Out-of-Towners*) direction is solid, especially a cut from discussing coffee to a great shot of an espresso and then a zoom into the characters on their first date. Francis Lai's (*A Man and a Woman*) score tugs at the heartstrings. Enjoy the romance. Cry at the heartbreak. Don't apologize for enjoying this film. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]
14. **Joe:** A perfect time-capsule film for the era, and one of the few that takes the point-of-view of the adults/parents. The connection between the two leads: the wealthy Bill (played by Dennis Patrick) and the middle-class and crass titular Joe (played by Peter Boyle; who would later go onto *Everybody Loves Raymond*) could be further developed. As the characters form an eventual and unlikely friendship, but the audience needs to see Bill being a tad disillusioned with his upper-crust friends for the pairing to really work (the screenplay is written by Norman Wexler). The plot could be improved a little bit as well, as it meanders for a bit. It also features a young Susan Sarandon in her film debut. However, it creates two characters who do not understand youth culture, and resent it; but gives them an opportunity for redemption (while also showing the youths not being the best people ever). The film is also one of the few to mention how World War II service messed with the heads of the Baby Boomer's parents. However, all of these parts would only have the film rank in the tier below, if it wasn't for the ending. The ending is amazing. Sadly, discussing would involve spoilers. Know that by surviving the slow and contrived parts, the ending pays off and completes the film. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Nominee]
13. **The Boys in the Band:** I should state that I saw the 2020 remake before ever watching the original film ('In 2020, there are simply better films with gay characters.') Whereas this original version is ground-breaking. Films of the era were not using the language in the film (her, queen, cunt, etc). The film is still veers a bit into stereotype, but it is easier to forgive given the year it was made. Director William Friedkin, doesn't do much (it's a bit ironic that he used all his single-location flair on *The Birthday Party*, which got him this job). Kenneth Nelson is good in the leading role and helps carry the film through the various lulls. The other actors are all solid, but none really pop off the screen as much as Nelson. Leonard Frey and Cliff Gorman are two of the better supporting actors. The flaws can be overlooked as the production is solid and ground-breaking enough. [Golden Globes – Best Newcomer Nominee]
12. **Patton:** The iconic opening scene still works and is a beautiful bit of production design and acting, especially as the entire film is George C. Scott's (*Petulia*) to command. The film does not work without Scott in the titular role (and perhaps as well without Karl Malden playing the foil as

General Bradley). As the film often relies on war scenes for action, the character development is often thru exposition (the first thirty-minutes after the opening credits are a chore), and there is a reliance on the film's relation to the Vietnam War to guide the themes. As unlike say, *Lawrence of Arabia*, Patton is essentially a static character, who's actions and motivations rarely change. And for a supposed military genius, the film never shows why he was successful beyond he was always on the attack. Some of the shots are nice, with shadows and lighting. The battle scenes work because of their grand scale, not exactly how they were filmed. The commentary about generals being generals, and wanting to be war hero, and the implication of Americans being addicted to war somewhat still works, but the connection to the time period of the release is needed more. Director Franklin J. Schaffner (*The Planet of the Apes*) made a good movie, but one wonders how it cleaned up at the Oscars. [Oscars – Best Picture]

11. **Where's Poppa?:** An absolutely hilarious and raw comedy directed by Carl Riener (*The Dick Van Dyke Show*). If the opening gorilla suit bit don't have you laughing, the Colonel (Barnard Hughes (*Midnight Cowboy*)) testifying, gloatingly, about his various war crimes will captivate you. Don't worry there are more gorilla suit bits, and great jokes about Central Park crime (the entire 'gang' is hilarious, especially a character aptly named Mothafucka; and Garrett Morris in a pre-*SNL* role). The leads of George Segal and Ruth Gordon are excellent as the mother-son duo who's close quarters forms the basis of the plot. Ron Leibman is great in his film debut and is able to sell some of the iffy jokes; especially when he contemplates calling the cop who gave him flowers. The is a hilarious comedy whose jokes stand the test of time. [WGA – Best Adapted Comedy Nominee]
10. **Little Big Man:** Directed by Arthur Penn (*Bonnie and Clyde*) this is an early revisionist western and comedy. It takes a bit to realize the film is a comedy and often a satire of genre tropes, but once one does the film becomes a lot more enjoyable. As the first parts are more of an inspiration for *Forrest Gump*, and Dustin Hofmann (*Midnight Cowboy* and *The Graduate*) doesn't exactly have the comedy chops down relative to his dramatic ability. Chief Dan George is the one nominated for an Oscar but Richard Mulligan's (*The Undefeated*) zany portrayal of General Custer really makes the movie; both in terms of the comedy and showcasing the evils of the US Army. Penn brings back the bloody ending of *Bonnie and Clyde* with the multiple slaughters of Native American tribes also being coated in blood; all done twenty years before *Dances With Wolves*. The film isn't perfect, and is obviously about a white man who takes to Indian Culture. The two-hour-twenty-minute run time is aw bit much (especially with the various satires of the genre taking up time unrelated to the treatment of Native Americans. Oh, and Faye Dunaway (*The Thomas Crown Affair*) shows up for two scenes and steals both of them. Yet, for 1970, there were not films this radical in regards to the Old West. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actor Nominee]
9. **The Ballad of Cable Hogue:** Directed by Sam Peckinpah, the film is a change of pace from his standard work. The film is a comedy Western (and in many ways sets the stage for *Blazing Saddles*, as this film satirizes a few tropes and subverts multiple genre conventions; especially the role of the preacher). There is also a great half-mast erection gag. Jason Robards (*Julius Caesar*) is great in the lead and brings the right level of cranky and charm. His portrayal of the title character, and that character's develop is what forms the crux of the film and it works. Most of the jokes land, and most are well done. The opening credits are nicely done as well. Stella Stevens is great as the female lead and prostitute. The shots of the desert are often beautiful. The film is a tribute the westerns of old, while also – much like *The Wild Bunch* – hinting at the end of an age and genre. [Sam Peckinpah]
8. **The Bird with the Crystal Plumage (L'uccello dalle piume di cristallo):** My first Italian giallo film; a horror-crime thriller genre. The kills are not that gruesome or scary. Instead the fright comes from the suspense which is aided by a jazzy score from Ennio Morricone and excellent framing/camerawork by Vittorio Storaro. It is an excellent directorial debut from Dario Argento. If anything the thriller aspect is more intriguing, and often functions like a superior *Zodiac*, down to

the killer phoning those investigating the murders. The film offers a motive for the killings at the end, but there is a subtext explanation which is the far more interesting motive. It is a great-looking suspenseful thriller, even if on the tamer side when it comes to the horror. [Giallo]

7. **Soldier Blue:** A bloody revisionist western that puts the blame squarely on the US during the Indian Wars. Unlike, *Little Big Man* the film does not aim to parody genre conventions, nor does it have much in the way of Native characters. Candice Bergen (*The Sand Pebbles*) plays the female lead, and is decent. The character often knows more than the male soldier, and when many female characters still barely contribute, it is nice to see this character take the lead (contemporary reviews apparently disliked the character who was an obvious parallel to the student protests). Whereas Peter Strauss is not very good as the co-lead. A subplot with Donald Pleasence's (*Cul-de-sac*) character is a nice distraction as he's always enjoyable. Yet, the real reason the film ranks here, is the bloody finale. The opening battle is bloody and sets the stage, but it is the finale that is mind-blowingly graphic, even by the standards of *Bonnie and Clyde* and *The Wild Bunch*. The ending is that jaw-dropping and remains a profound statement. [Western]

Tier 2: Must Watches Are Usually Tier 3, But It's A Week Year

6. **Catch-22:** I have not read the source novel, and a fair bit of the criticism was aimed at how the film adapted the source material (which is a criticism I always find to be lazy, as the film is an entirely new work of art). However the primary criticism of the film is related to a poor *adaptation* of the source material: there are simply too many characters in the film. Bob Newhart nearly steals the show in his single scene or two, but then nothing else is done with his character. Each actor is great in their small supporting role: Norman Fell, Martin Sheen, and of course Orson Wells (the cast is ridiculously stacked). Yet each character gets lost along the way because there are too many of them. Yet despite these flaws, the film can still rank here as it is a solid war satire. The supporting actors who are given larger roles are great, especially Jon Voight (*Midnight Cowboy*) who had an argument for a Best Supporting Actor nomination. Mike Nichols (*Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* and *The Graduate*) is excellent as the director with David Watkin's (*Marat/Sade*) cinematography being excellent. Many shots are one-take with the camera roaming around or remaining still; the opening shot is amazingly crafted. The lighting is great as well, with a few shots masked in darkness. The film was overlooked for some good reason (Nichols had better films) but that does not mean it is not worth seeing. [BAFTA – Best Cinematography Nominee]
5. **Five Easy Pieces:** One of the few films on the list I'd seen before. The first time I saw the film I wasn't super high on it, and I would still say that is roughly true (1970 was a relatively weak year). The film has a fair bit in common with *The Landlord*, and although *Pieces* is more subtle it often leaves too much for the audience to interpret; why did Jack Nicholson's character leave in the first place? There is too much vagueness for the film to fully come together. Supporting performances by Lois Smith and Karen Black (*Easy Rider*) are well done. The lesbian(?) hitchhikers get rather tiresome, even if they help set up the finale. The final sequence is a wowzer, with beautiful (yet dreary) cinematography from László Kovács. The ending alone, probably puts the film in this tier, instead of the top of the previous one. The script by Carole Eastman is rather tight, with multiple great callbacks, even if it leaves too many ideas vague. It is a solid example, of New Hollywood, but it isn't quite as good as some of its lofty accolades imply. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee]
4. **Le Cercle Rouge:** Written and directed by Jean-Pierre Melville who is once again reunited with Alain Delon (both *Le Samourai*). Unfortunately this film is not as good, but that does mean much given the quality of *Samourai*. This film has many of the same hallmarks; minimal dialogue, amazing cinematography, and slow building tension. The infamous thirty-minute heist scene with a single-word spoken is amazing. The tension slowly ratchets up, as the viewer learns of the exact plan to

rob the jewels; but the plan is never revealed or detailed, only that one of the members had cased out the joint and provided a brief rundown. The plot ‘keeps’ the audience guessing, as that character motivations and plot developments are not as simple as they initially seem; the payoff comes a few minutes later (detailing these examples leads to a few spoilers). Melville has once again crafted a tense crime noir with minimal dialogue. [Jean-Pierre Melville]

3. **The Landlord:** This coming-of-age social drama could be in a lower tier, except the cinematography from Gordon Willis is outstanding. It was one of Willis’ first films (though not his first) and the shots are amazing. Multiple brilliantly framed shots looking out doors and windows. A scene lit with a red light is gorgeous. The scene with the axe is also well-composed. Willis elevates the film and it is easy to see why Francis Ford Coppola requested him for *The Godfather*. The film is Hal Hasby’s directorial debut and it sets the stage for his career making social dramas. The film handles race relations rather well, though a few bits do come across as dated, it for the most parts holds up well. Beau Bridges (*For Love of Ivy*) is rather good as the new titular landlord and plays the role of a sheltered rich kid rather well. Diana Sands steals every scene she is in and should have gotten the Supporting Actress nomination instead of Lee Grant (*In the Heat of the Night*) who is good in her own right but has a more bombastic role compared to the subtleties Sands needed to convey. The main flaw (beyond that the social commentary is a times too-on-the-nose) is that the relationship between Bridges character and his (mixed-race) love interest is not fully developed. We never quite get a sense why she loves him. Yet despite this flaw the script remains frequently funny, and always authentic. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actress Nominee]
2. **I Never Sang for My Father:** Adapted by from Robert Anderson’s (*The Sand Pebbles*) stage play of the same name, the film remains play-like, but one rarely notices that a play is being filmed. One reason is that Anderson’s writing is tight and engaging, with characters slowly being unfolded. Gene Hackman (*Marooned*) is excellent as the son (and he is the lead character; some major category fraud was at play with this film), while Melvyn Douglas is equally good as the father (and in a supporting role or co-lead; again the category fraud!). Hackman is also reunited with *Bonnie and Clyde* supporting-star Estelle Parsons, who plays his sister. The film excels as both the father and son are flawed humans (and it is easy to see which insecurities were passed down to from father and son; including from the grandfather). As the script and the actors work to portray each as flawed, but then also reveal a bit more of their background which (partially) redeems them. The weaving of these stories finally comes together in an emotional climax. One does wish the cinematography was a bit better. Yet, it is still a deeply moving personal film detailing the trials and tribulations of a father-son relationship. [Oscars – Best Adapted Screenplay Nominee]

Tier 1: A Near Masterpiece

1. **M*A*S*H:** The film which launched the iconic TV series, and that does make rating a tad harder, given the TV series lasted 256 episodes and we got to spend a lot more time with the various characters (but steals gags from the movie). And there is also the chance the series finale is better than the movie? For the most part, the film should not work; it is very episodic and potentially has too many characters. However in true Robert Altman-style (*Brewster McCloud*) he makes the massive cast work and gives each character just enough time to be more than a stand-in. Ring Lardner Jr.’s (*not naming names*) script is packed with jokes. The opening credits set to ‘Suicide is Painless’ are great, and it is a shocker the song was not even nominated for Best Song. The film embodies the spirit of New American Cinema; poking fun at corruption (the trip to Japan for the Congressmen’s son), religion (all while keeping the character of Father Mulcahy grounded and well-intentioned; the attacks on religion are broad-picture—Mulcahy’s delivery of ‘they were drafted’ might be the best line of the entire film), the stuck-up-ness of officials (everything Frank Burns does), while also including racism and the not-so-subtle commentary on Vietnam (although set in Korea, it’s near impossible to see

the commentary as America's involvement in Vietnam), though some of the bits do come across as a bit sexist today. Altman's cast of characters often talk over each other and multiple conversations occur at once. Framing the episodes around the camp announcements, provides a flow to a film that would otherwise lack it (and that the speakers play a pivotal role in the film while broadcasting Frank Burns' escapades helps ensure they fit seamlessly into the film; that one is a close-up of a speaker and an American flag serves as a nice juxtaposition). Although not much actual guts and injuries are shown, the patients are often covered in blood and the doctors always covered when operating; the film doesn't need to be explicit to convey the carnage. This is one of the better films of all-time, and a perfect early example of the floodgates about to be opened in film over the next ten years. [Oscars – Best Adapted Screenplay]